Unit 11. The Bible and biblical ministry (Reflection)

Overview

This unit flows out of the study of 2 Timothy 3:14-17. It explores the nature and the purpose of the Bible and what that means for ministry in practice. It follows the BUILD ERA model of reflection; the 'Action' component focuses on personal Bible study and prayer.

Outline

- Introduction to the Bible and biblical ministry
- Encountering different views of the Bible
- Reflection to gain wisdom about God's word
- Action flowing from the nature and purpose of Scripture
- Conclusion
- EXTRA: The BUILD modules and the flow of the Bible

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Repeat the process of theological reflection learnt in Unit 9
2. Show what 2 Timothy says about the nature and purpose of the Bible
3. Explain how the nature of the Bible relates to its purpose
4. Evaluate the relationship between private and public Bible study and prayer
5. Apply the lessons of Unit 10 to personal Bible study
6. Present a simple pattern of Bible study to others

11.1 INTRODUCTION TO THE BIBLE AND BIBLICAL MINISTRY

The passage we have just encountered contains an important statement about the nature and the purpose of Scripture:

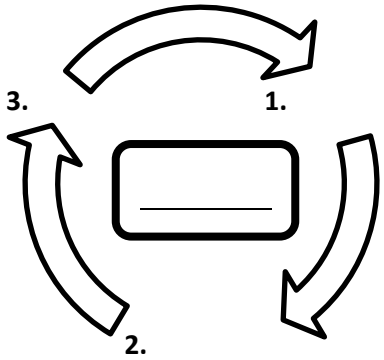
> "All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness, so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work." (2 Tim 3:16-17)

The letter 'B' in the word 'BUILD' stands for 'Biblical' and we have already learnt a number of things about the Bible. For example in Unit 2 we learnt that the Bible, God's written word, is the principal and controlling way in which we hear God's voice today. This unit takes this further by looking in more depth at the nature and purpose of the Bible.

Unit 9 introduced some steps of theological reflection:

- What were the three steps and what word helps us to remember them?

- The steps can also be understood as a cycle. Can you fill in the blanks in the diagram below?



The summary table for the three steps of theological reflection is given again below:

Step and description	Definition	Activity	Outcome
Encounter something in God's world and God's word with a desire for wisdom.	To meet something new and surprising	Describe	Discoveries
Reflection on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.	Pause for thought and go deeper	Consider	Principles
Action in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.	Do something new or different	Plan	Practice

Keep returning to this table as you go through the unit.

11.2 ENCOUNTERING DIFFERENT VIEWS OF THE BIBLE

Remember, the first step is to **encounter** something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom. In this case it is the issue of the Bible and biblical ministry.

On this occasion we will first encounter our own ideas and those of others around us before encountering God's word on the matter. There are reasons for this. Firstly, it is often easier to describe our own experiences and the experiences of others before looking at the Bible. Secondly, that then naturally prepares us to see what the Bible says by way of connection or contrast.

11.2.1 Encountering different views of the Bible in the world around us

Think first about yourself and the world around you. Put a mirror up to your own life and ministry as well as considering what others are saying and doing and describe your attitudes to the Bible and your understanding of it. These questions will help you:

- Describe some of the things that you hear people saying about the Bible in churches or elsewhere in society.

- What other sources of wisdom and insight do people turn to for direction or help in their lives and ministries?

- What do people mean when they claim that their ministry is ‘biblical’?

- How would you describe the place the Bible has in your ministry and the ministry of those around you?

11.2.2 Encountering what God’s word says about the Bible

Now begin to describe what you have been learning in the Pastoral Epistles and the discoveries you have been making, particularly in 2 Timothy. Focus on 2 Timothy 3:14-17 before discussing any other passages that you have noticed on this theme.

- What do you think the Christians in Ephesus were saying about the Scriptures? Defend your answer with evidence from specific chapters and verses.

- What is striking about what 2 Timothy 3:14-17 and other parts of the Pastoral Epistles have to say about the Bible?

- What have you encountered in our studies so far? Begin to describe what the epistles seem to be saying about the Bible.

11.3 REFLECTION TO GAIN WISDOM ABOUT GOD'S WORD

11.3.1 Considering the issue and developing principles

Remember, the second step is to **reflect** on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom. In the discipline of reflection you **consider** your discoveries and develop **principles**, in this case about the Bible and biblical ministry.

Take a step back and **consider** carefully what we have encountered in God’s world and God’s word. Remember that diagrams, drawings and even maps of a local community can help this process of reflection. You could picture the place of Scripture in the place and find ways of drawing that. Or you might want to return to the BUILD emblem or logo in Unit 1, section 1. Begin to capture some **principles** that you are learning.

Ask and answer questions such as:

- Why might people have these attitudes and understandings? Note the reasons behind the description and discoveries. Give explanations.

- What light does the gospel, the good news of God's grace, shed on our understanding of the Bible, what it is and what it does? Keep the gospel at the heart of your reflection.

- What Bible passages and themes are particularly relevant as you form principles about the Bible and its place in ministry? List a few Scriptures that are important.

- What pictures come to mind that help you to understand God's perspective on the Bible and its place in ministry? Draw any diagrams or maps that help you to understand what is going on.

- What principles seem to come from this process? List these lessons you are learning.

11.3.2 Drawing together some principles about the Bible

Your Trainer will help you to draw some of these ideas together under two headings:

1. The nature of the Bible – "All Scripture is …" (2 Tim 3:16)

2. The purpose of the Bible – "… and is useful for …" (2 Tim 3:16)

Your Trainer will be able to help and guide you in this under those headings.

1. The nature of the Bible

a) Our Bible is God's words through people's words
"All Scripture is God-breathed..." Some translations say "inspired" by God. This does not mean the Bible is an inspiring or exciting story. It is inspirational and exciting but it is so much more than that. "Inspired" means that it is breathed out by God the Holy Spirit. The words we read are God's words. But they are also human words, one and at the same time. Paul commands Timothy to "reflect on what I am saying, for the Lord will give you insight into all this". As we read Paul's writing we become aware that he had a sense that he was speaking God's words. 2 Peter clearly makes that claim when he says this:

> "Bear in mind that our Lord's patience means salvation, **just as our dear brother Paul also wrote you with the wisdom that God gave him**. He writes the same way in all his letters, speaking in them of these matters. His letters contain some things that are hard to understand, which ignorant and unstable people distort, **as they do the other Scriptures**, to their own destruction" (2 Peter 3:15-16).

Paul's words and the words of the other apostles were considered to be God's words. The Bible is God's word through human words. God is the Bible's primary author, but he communicates through human authors. So what?

The Bible is people's words…	**The Bible is God's words…**
Each book of the Bible has a particular historical setting and audience in mind.	The Bible is relevant for all people in all places at all times.
We need to take the context into account and aim to discover the original meaning of any passage for its audience.	We need to handle it carefully, submit to its message and discover the relevance of any passage for us today.
The question of what it **meant** originally is vital.	The question of what it **means** today is equally important.
Explanation is important.	**Application** is important.

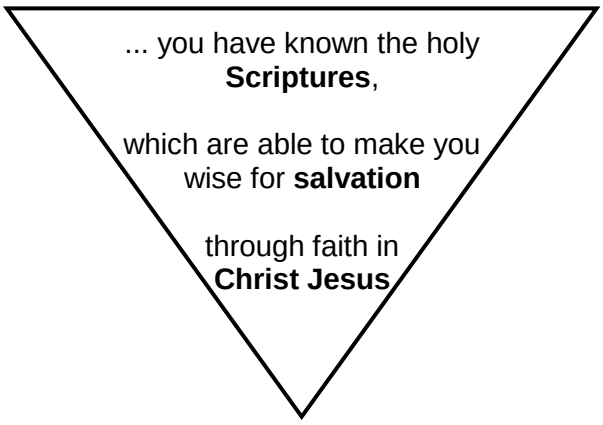
b) Our Bible has been formed around Christ the Messiah
Remember that Paul would not have had the Bible we have today; he was writing parts of the Bible. So how did the Bible come into being? Paul would have had access to the Old Testament Scriptures and some of the early writings about Christ and possibly some letters. Paul asked Timothy to "bring... my scrolls, especially the parchments" in 2 Timothy 4:13.

Because of the nature of the Bible – with Christ and Salvation at the centre – the Bible forms itself around those, as though Christ and the gospel were a magnet.

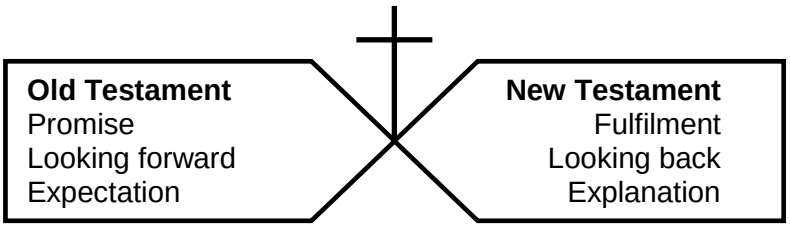
We trust the Bible because we trust Christ himself. He is our starting point and Christ himself trusted the Old Testament Scriptures and referred to them repeatedly (excluding the Apocrypha, which has value but is not Scripture). Jesus then predicted the formation of the New Testament, through the writings of the Apostles, helped by the Holy Spirit. Jesus explains this in John 16:12-15. The church then closed the Bible once all the writings that were clearly Apostolic and that pointed to Christ and the gospel were gathered together.

c) Our Bible links the Scriptures with Salvation and the Saviour
The Bible is the words of God (Scriptures) about the word of God (the gospel) which is all about the Word of God (Christ, the saviour).

2 Timothy 3:15



d) Our Bible links the Old Testament and the New Testament
Building on this, because of the relationship between Scripture and salvation and the Saviour there is a unity to the Bible – both Old Testament and New Testament belong together and are a single story on the single theme of salvation with the one hero, God in Christ. We saw this in Unit 3, point the Participants back to that unit and this simple illustration:



The Old Testament is like a light shining ahead to Christ and the New Testament – Christ and the New Testament only makes sense in the light of the Old Testament.

The New Testament is like a light shining back on Christ and the Old Testament – Christ and the Old Testament only makes sense in the light of the New Testament.

e) Our Bible is sufficient and complete
The outcome of this unity of the Bible, which forms around Christ and the gospel, is that it is complete and sufficient. In the last unit we could not help noticing the words in 2 Tim 3:16 that spoke of the completeness of the Bible:

> "All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness, [17]so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work."

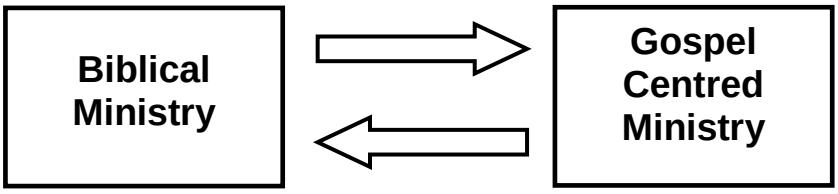
There is no hint that anything else is needed. This is encouraging. Scripture is enough for salvation and for knowing the saviour. Yes, other books are useful, but they are not essential, as we have already noted.

2. The purpose of the Bible

The nature of Scripture leads to its purpose. Just as there are five points we have made about the nature of Scripture (like five fingers on one hand) we can make five points about the purpose of Scripture (like five fingers on another hand). All of these link together.

The nature of Scripture	**The purpose of Scripture**
a) It is God's words through people's words	It directs our preaching and teaching
b) It has Christ at the centre	It points people to Christ
c) It is about salvation and leads to the Saviour	It leads people to be saved through Christ
d) It is formed around Christ and his gospel and teaches that gospel	It preserves the gospel and makes it central
e) It is sufficient in every way	It equips leaders

We have talked about 'Gospel centred ministry' – Biblical ministry is inseparable from Gospel centred ministry. Gospel centred ministry means that we will want to keep rediscovering and rejoicing in the Gospel that the Bible teaches. And the more we look at the Bible the more we will be excited by and driven by the true gospel in presents.



11.4 ACTION FLOWING FROM THE NATURE AND PURPOSE OF SCRIPTURE

Paul tells Timothy that Scripture is *useful*, it is a practical book. But we need to use it according to its nature and purpose, which we have learnt about. We have noted five areas in which it is useful:

a) For preaching and teaching

b) For pointing people to Christ

c) For leading people to salvation

d) For keeping the gospel central

e) For equipping leaders

All five are connected together in different ways. One way is that the first four feed into the last, “so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work” (2 Tim 3:17).

And that includes taking the nature and purpose of Scripture very seriously in our own lives. We must be equipped by the word if we are to equip others from the word; we need to watch our own “life and doctrine closely” (1 Tim 4:16).

The rest of this unit will focus on our own, personal, study of Scripture and the prayer that belongs with it.

11.4.1 Personal Bible study and prayer

Discuss these questions:

- Is Christian ministry a profession or a vocation? In other words, to what extent is our ministry a position we hold in the church and how much is it about God’s calling on our lives? At what points do you feel a sense of conflict between your position as a church leader and your personal call to serve God?

- It is all too easy for church leaders to be so busy feeding others from God’s word that they starve themselves. Have you ever felt like that? How did it come to that point and how have you been able to change the situation?

The life-giving message is not simply something to be passed on and taught. Timothy must live by the Bible and benefit from its gospel and teaching. For example, he also says, “You then, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus” (2 Tim 2:1).

The Pastoral Epistles have a great deal to say about the disciplines of Bible study and prayer, both public and private, and Paul links those disciplines to Timothy’s own spiritual health as well as to the health of the local church.

- In groups ‘skim read’ 1 Timothy and 2 Timothy and note where Paul talks directly or indirectly about Bible study and prayer, both in public and in private.
  (To ‘skim read’ means to cast your eye quickly down the text in order to spot these ideas.)
  Begin with 1 Timothy and focus on 1 Tim 2:1-8; 1 Tim 3:1-10; 1 Tim 4:6-16.
  If you have time go back to 2 Timothy and look at 2 Tim 1:13-14; 2 Tim 2:1-7, 14-15, 22-26; 2 Tim 3:14-17; and 2 Tim 4:1-5.

- As you do this, fill in the table below using those discoveries, noting down some verses and the ideas they contain.

1. Public use of the Bible	**2. Public Prayer**
For example: 1 Tim 4:13	For example: 1 Tim 2:1-2, 8
3. Private use of the Bible	**4. Private Prayer**

Both Bible study and prayer are essential for our spiritual health. But what we do publicly should be an expression of what we do privately, on our own before God. Read 1 Tim 4:6 again, which makes the link between our private faith and our public ministry. Our public prayer and study must flow from a genuine personal experience. Jesus tells us not to be hypocrites (Matt 6:5-15).

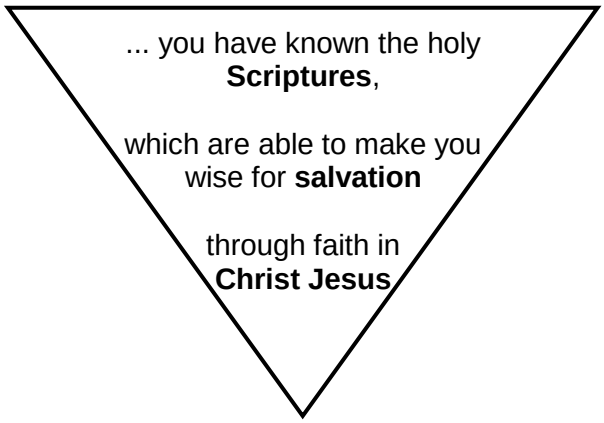
- To what extent is that true of your life and the life of others in your group? Be honest with one another and before God and end any discussion in prayer.

11.4.2 Studying the Bible according to the nature of the Bible

What we learnt in the last unit about the Bible and biblical ministry will help us to study the Bible in private as well as in public.

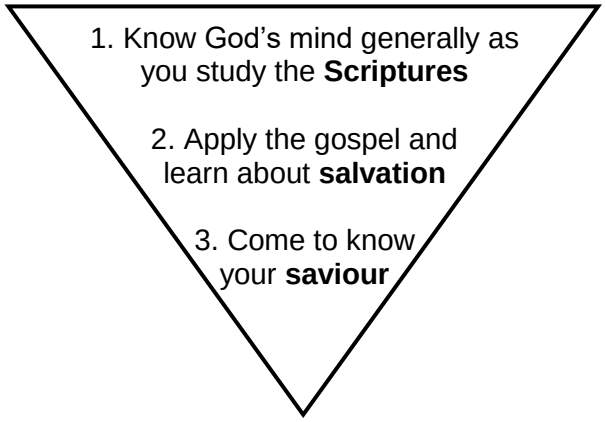
For example, we noticed the relationship between Scripture, Salvation and the Saviour.

2 Timothy 3:15



That means that we need to study the Bible with those three elements in mind. We need to ‘go with the grain’ and study Scripture in the way that God has designed it to be studied (just as we saw that a sculptor uses the grain within the wood he is working on). As you read the Bible for yourself and for your own encouragement bear in mind these three things:

2 Timothy 3:15



In John's gospel Jesus commands us to take all three steps through this warning to the religious leaders of his day:

> "You study the Scriptures diligently because you think that in them you have eternal life. These are the very Scriptures that testify about me, yet you refuse to come to me to have life" (John 5:39-40).

- How can we make sure that our own study of the Scriptures lead to salvation in and through Jesus?

- Look back at the last unit and note how other aspects of the nature and purpose of the Bible can help you to study it and receive God's grace through it.

11.4.3 A pattern for personal Bible study

The principles we have been learning for encountering the Bible apply to personal Bible study and prayer too. But it is helpful to have a simple way of approaching the Bible on a daily basis to hear from God. The more we study the Bible in depth for public ministry the more it will help us to hear God's word in private; and the more we hear God's voice in private, the more it will empower our public preaching.

Here is one simple pattern to follow, which can apply to any passage of Scripture. Again it uses the word 'GOSPEL' to help us to remember it, and as such it is a way of preaching the gospel to ourselves day by day:

G is for **God**
As you meditate on a Bible passage look first for what it teaches about **God**. Focus particularly on God's character, beginning with his might and majesty.

O is for **Ourselves**
The Bible also tells us the truth about **ourselves**. It is a mirror in which we see our own brokenness. Look for ways in which the passage shows up your sinfulness, as well as any signs of God's love for you.

S is for **Salvation**
Turn to note anything that points us to our **salvation** in Christ Jesus. These might be truths that lead you to Christ's saving work on the cross.

P is for **Promise**
There may be indicators of the **promise** of the God's Holy Spirit and his grace and gifts for us today. Truths about the work of the promised Holy Spirit can bring us assurance of all that God has done for us.

E is for **Eternity**
The passage may point you to **eternity**, to the life of the world to come, or to Christ's return and his future judgement. If it does, it is important to take that perspective into your day.

L is for **Life**
Finally apply all this to your **life** today. Look for commands to obey, examples to follow, warnings to heed, or promises you can hold on to. Apply the message to your hopes and fears for the day.

- Practise this approach now as a group on a passage from the Pastoral Epistles. Take Titus 3:3-8 for example.

Here are some other practical suggestions:

1. Use lectionary readings for this discipline, and select a short passage to reflect on. This provides a balanced diet.

2. Use a notebook and pen so that you can concentrate and develop ideas.

3. Write down and memorise a key verse in the text to take into the day.

4. Imagine someone asking you what God has said to you from his word today. How would you answer them?

- Share other ideas in your group to help one another to feed from the Scriptures.

11.4.4 Praying from the word

There is no better moment to pray than as you study the Bible or straight after you have finished. As God speaks to you, respond in prayer. Many people find the acronym 'ACTS' a helpful one to use.

A is for **Adoration**. Turn what you have learnt about the Lord into praise.

C is for **Confession**. That will automatically lead to the confession of sin.

T is for **Thanksgiving**. First for your salvation, as you continue to preach the gospel to yourself, and then for the many other blessings God has given you.

S is for **Supplication**. 'Supplication' means to ask for something, we can end by laying our requests before God.

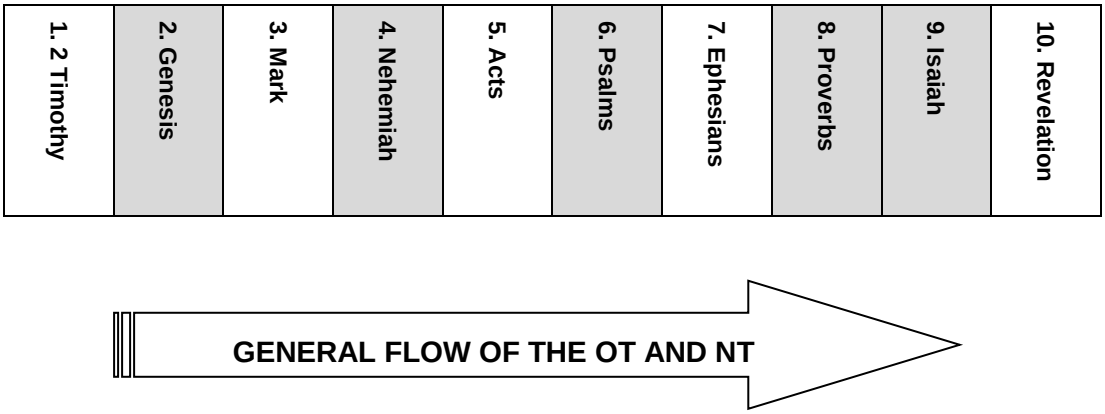
11.5 CONCLUSION

There is an extra section below that not only reinforces what we have been learning, but also explains the flow of the modules in the BUILD curriculum. You might like to cover that now, or return to it later.

Whatever you decide to do, pause and close your main time together by turning some of the key things you have learnt into prayer, using the 'ACTS' pattern above. For example, you might have new things to adore God for, now you have understood the wonder of his word. Give time to prayer.

11.6 EXTRA: THE BUILD MODULES AND THE FLOW OF THE BIBLE

As an extra for personal or group study: one practical way in which the shape of the Bible is used in BUILD is in shaping its curriculum. The way the modules have been arranged is designed to teach some of the principles taught above. The modules follow the flow of the Bible and this is illustrated using the key books the modules are based around:



- What else do you notice about the arrangement of the books? What might this achieve?

- Are there any exceptions to this? Your Trainer will help to point these out and explain them.